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THE EFFECT OF EMPHASIZING PROOFREADING AND
SELECTED BASIC ENGLISH RULES IN A BEGINNING
TYPEWRITING CLASS AT THE COLLEGE LEVEL.

THE UNIVERSITY OF ALABAMA, ED.D., 1978

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PREVIEW

THE EFFECT OF EMPHASIZING PROOFREADING AND SELECTED
BASIC ENGLISH RULES IN A BEGINNING TYPEWRITING
CLASS AT THE COLLEGE LEVEL

by
VIRGINIA HAMNER SNYDER

A DISSERTATION

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1978

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CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

Among the major contemporary problems in business education listed by Smith in 1977 is one confronting all areas of education: "Those who enroll in business courses exhibit an amazing deficiency in reading, writing, and computing skills."¹ To help alleviate this national problem, an interdisciplinary instructional approach is needed to aid students in achieving more effective communication skills. Teachers are encouraged to explore possibilities in their individual courses for including constructive practice in oral and written expression.

Statement of the Problem

Since typewriting is a communication skill in itself by virtue of providing copy faster and easier to read than longhand, the course affords many challenging opportunities for developing skills related to typewritten messages. Bennett has stated, "Typewriting is the prime course in the business curriculum for the integration of

¹Genevieve Smith, Techniques and Activities for Teaching Business Skills--Featuring the Mini-Company Approach (West Nyack, New York: Parker Publishing Company Inc., 1977), p. 5.

communication skills."¹ According to Erickson, research evidence indicates that the typewriter is a relatively unexploited tool as an aid to learning.² There is considerable evidence that typewriting improves facility in language arts if it is taught for that purpose. Ancillary benefits from learning to typewrite include improved spelling, punctuation, vocabulary, composition, organization, and other language skills. In writing of the interdisciplinary nature of typewriting, Grill points out the contributions that the disciplines of English, psychology, and mathematics have made to the study of typewriting.³ Conversely, he recognizes that many significant contributions can be made to other subjects by typewriting. According to Bennett, "Our challenge is clear, but we cannot expect communication skills to be learned only incidentally. They must be programmed and planned as a definite part of the instructional pattern . . ."⁴

Any statement of overall objectives of the typewriting course normally includes related learnings necessary for effective written communication. For example, the

¹James C. Bennett, "Integrate Communication Skills Into the Secondary Curriculum," Business Education Forum 32 (November 1977):29.

²Lawrence W. Erickson, "Using the Typewriter for Learning: Writing," Balance Sheet (December 1976/January 1977), p. 149.

³George P. Grill, "Interdisciplinary Nature of Typewriting," Business Education Forum 19 (December 1964): 19-20.

⁴Bennett, "Integrate Communication Skills," p. 29.

fifth objective of typewriting enumerated by the Georgia Department of Education is as follows: "To increase students' ability to spell, punctuate, syllabicate, and to compose good English sentences and to integrate these related learnings with typewriting skills."¹ In actual practice, however, Hertz surmised:

In terms of accomplishments by the students, emphasis in the classroom and practice by the teachers, the objectives of typewriting may be broken down into two categories--primary and secondary.

It would seem that the primary objectives--those accomplished the most, emphasized the most, and practiced the most--are concerned with the following areas of typewriting: parts of the typewriter, typewriting techniques, margins, straight-copy speed and accuracy, centering and tabulation, business letters, and manuscripts and outlines.

It also seems that the secondary objectives--those accomplished the least, emphasized the least, and practiced the least--are concerned with the following areas of typewriting: composition, proofreading, erasing, problem solving, attitude, work habits, and mailable copy.²

Regarding composition at the typewriter, in 1968 Cook submitted:

When typewriting was first introduced into the public school curriculum, it served two primary purposes: (1) to provide senior high school students with "touch" copying skills and (2) to provide elementary school students with a greater facility in reading and composition. . . . Today, many teachers extol both virtues in teaching typewriting. Most, however, put the major emphasis on copying rather than writing at the typewriter. A substantial amount of research over

¹Allien R. Russon and S. J. Wanous, Philosophy and Psychology of Teaching Typewriting, 2nd ed. (Cincinnati: South-Western Publishing Company, 1973), pp. 25-26.

²Daniel G. Hertz, "Are We Making Robots Out of Our Typewriting Students?" Business Education Forum 27 (December 1972):26.

the past 45 years clearly demonstrates that a teacher who is so inclined can accomplish three objectives in her typewriting classes:

- Teach the basic principles of touch typing
- Teach the student how to use the typewriter as a writing tool
- Teach content--i.e., spelling, economics, language arts, and so forth¹

In the considered opinion of Tonne, Popham, and Freeman:

. . . the expected outcomes for a typewriting course vary from school to school, from teacher to teacher, and from student to student. There are, however, basic objectives identifiable for all beginning typewriting instruction. Their emphases vary in degree with the various situations in which typewriting is taught, but not in basic essentiality.²

Additional research is needed to determine ways of integrating communication skills in the typewriting course and the effect of emphasizing these skills on the fundamental acquisition of rapid and accurate typewriting skills. While related skills are customarily included to some degree in advanced typewriting courses, the greater contribution to the goal of improving written communication skills among students would be found in beginning classes where substantially larger numbers of students are enrolled.

Over five million students study typewriting each year in middle and elementary schools, junior and senior

¹Fred S. Cook, "Use 'Thought Starters' for Composing at the Typewriter," Business Education World, June 1968, pp. 12-13, 19-20.

²Herbert A. Tonne, Estelle L. Popham, and M. Herbert Freeman, Methods of Teaching Business Subjects (New York: Gregg Division, McGraw-Hill Book Company, 1965), p. 116.

high schools, postsecondary institutions, private business schools, and adult courses.¹ Seven of ten students receive one year or less of typewriting instruction.² The largest typewriting enrollments are found in senior high school grades ten, eleven, and twelve.³ Typewriting enrollment in secondary schools ranks second only to the enrollment in the required English courses.⁴ Typewriting provides more job opportunities for students than any other single course.⁵ Because of increased enrollments of both nonvocational and vocational students, Tonne strongly suggests that teachers of typewriting "examine and reexamine the changes in subject matter and methodology demanded by the situation."⁶

A major component of proficiency in the skill of typewriting is proofreading. However, according to Gryder and Gryder:

. . . proofreading has become one of the neglected areas of instruction in typewriting. . . . A first-year business teacher in a large secondary school reports that the major problem with proofreading is that students do not recognize errors as errors. They do not

¹John L. Rowe and Laverne Thoreson, "A Historical Development of Typewriting," Business Education--Yesterday, Today, and Tomorrow, National Business Education Association Yearbook, No. 14, 1976, p. 106.

²Ibid., p. 107.

³Ibid., p. 106.

⁴James R. Meehan, "Trends in the Teaching of Typewriting," Journal of Business Education 52 (April 1977): 308.

⁵Ibid., p. 307.

⁶Tonne, Popham, and Freeman, Methods, p. 112.

know how to spell properly, to punctuate, to apply rules of grammar, and indeed cannot distinguish many of these errors. . . . A variation on the theme expressed by collegiate typewriting teachers is that students do not take time to proofread carefully. . . . A major responsibility of the typewriting instructor on the collegiate level--or indeed any level--is to make certain that students develop the habit of proofreading everything they type.¹

Wong reported that a survey undertaken by Ewart in the 1960s provided supporting evidence for widespread proofreading disability.² A 369-word test containing thirty-eight errors was given to 2,538 subjects. Only one person found all the mistakes. Table 1 ranks the subjects by groups according to their mean total error scores:

TABLE 1
PROOFREADING SURVEY SUMMARY

Group	Mean Total Errors
Business Teachers	8.9
Professional Secretaries	9.8
College Students	12.0
Miscellaneous Adults	13.2
High School Students	13.3
Junior High School Students	15.9
Mean % inaccuracy level for all groups:	32%

Source: Margaret J. Ewart, Unpublished study to determine types of straight copy proofreading errors made by typewriting students and others (Corvallis, Oregon State University, 1963).

¹Robert Gryder and Isabelle Gryder, "Proofreading: A Neglected Area of Typewriting Instruction," Business Education Forum 30 (October 1975):18-19.

²Shirley Wong, "What Are We Doing About Proofreading," Journal of Business Education 49 (December 1973):122.

According to Wise, proofreading includes locating and correcting typographical errors as well as errors in (1) content, (2) format, (3) grammar, (4) spelling, (5) capitalization, (6) punctuation, (7) word usage, and (8) word division.¹ Proofreading, then, brings into focus four basic English components which are particularly appropriate to stress in the typewriting course: (1) capitalization, (2) punctuation, (3) spelling, and (4) word division. The problem of instructional planning and methods is to stress these components without sacrificing maximum development of rapid and accurate keyboard manipulation. Crawford has pointed out:

The purpose of typewriting instruction should not be diluted or minimized. Regardless of the title of the course being offered, the primary goal of any course in typewriting is mastery of the machine called "type-writer." No amount of allusion to other purposes--to incidental or concomitant learnings--can alter the fact that the chief aim of typewriting courses is to teach students how to typewrite most efficiently.²

Further research is needed to aid in the development of systematic methods of emphasizing proofreading and selected basic English rules in beginning typewriting and to determine the effect of this emphasis. This need to aid students in achieving more effective writing skills is the problem which prompted the study.

¹Elva Lea Wise, "Proofreading is for Everyone," Balance Sheet, December 1974/January 1975, p. 172.

²T. James Crawford, "Fundamental Considerations for Successful Typewriting Instruction," Business Education Forum, 12 (October 1962):20.

Need for the Study

Declining national test scores

In October, 1975, the National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP) Report on Writing Mechanics for 1969-1974¹ was released, showing a decline in literacy skills which correlated with declining average national test scores in the Scholastic Aptitude Test (SAT) and American College Test (ACT) since 1964. The development of NAEP was, according to Shafer, a response to the public's growing concern about the quality of education.² The Seventh Annual Gallup Poll of Public Attitudes Toward Education, conducted in June, 1975, revealed that the third major reason in the opinion of the respondents for declining national test scores was "not enough emphasis on basics," following (1) "students' lack of interest/motivation" and (2) "lack of discipline in the home and school."³

In 1976, in the Eighth Annual Gallup Poll, 59 percent of the respondents believed that the decline in national test scores in recent years meant that the quality

¹National Assessment of Educational Progress, Writing Mechanics 1969-1974: A Capsule Description of Changes in Writing Mechanics (Washington: U. S. Government Printing Office, October 1975).

²Robert E. Shafer, "National Assessment: Backgrounds and Projections--1975," Paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Conference on English Education, Colorado Springs, Colorado, 1975 (ERIC Document Reproduction Service, ED 108 211, 1975).

³George H. Gallup, "Seventh Annual Gallup Poll of Public Attitudes Toward Education," Phi Delta Kappan 57 (December 1975):236.

of education was declining.¹ The 1976 poll also showed that the respondents' top choice of ways to improve the quality of public education was "devoting more attention to the teaching of basic skills."²

After the NAEP report was issued, Newsweek (December 8, 1975) published the cover story, "Why Johnny Can't Write," which was read by over two million Americans. The article exposed the current condition of the teaching of writing. It purported that the present state of English skills would not qualify high school graduates to undertake college work nor enable clerical workers to hold jobs. Moreover, the article pointed out that some college students were graduating although semi-illiterate. This story fit the national mood of the 1970s, and its ready acceptance paralleled that of its predecessor, Rudolf Flesch's Why Johnny Can't Read³ of the 1950s.

Literacy "crisis"

A government report released in October, 1975, pertaining to a four-year study at the University of Texas documented the fact that one of every five American adults is functionally illiterate and unable to cope effectively with daily duties and activities. The report also disclosed

¹George H. Gallup, "Eighth Annual Gallup Poll of the Public's Attitude Toward the Public Schools," Phi Delta Kappan 58 (October 1976):190.

²Ibid., p. 189.

³Rudolf Franz Flesch, Why Johnny Can't Read--And What You Can Do About It (New York: Harper, 1955).

that one out of three adults functions on a minimal level in the nine areas of the knowledges and skills tested: occupational information, consumer economics, government and law, health, community resources, reading, problem-solving, computation, and writing.¹

Other examples of a "literacy crisis" in public education have been noted:

1. In recent years more than one-third of the applicants to the journalism school of the University of Wisconsin at Madison have not been able to meet the minimum requirements in spelling, grammar, word usage, and punctuation²
2. In the University of California system, half of those admitted as freshmen in 1974 were required to take a remedial English course. The freshman class consisted of the top eight percent of California high school graduates³
3. Thirty to fifty percent of applicants to journalism programs at Minnesota, Texas, and North Carolina have recently failed basic spelling, punctuation, and usage tests⁴
4. Twelve to fifteen percent of all American students fail to read beyond an elementary level⁵

¹William W. Brickman, "Adult Functional Competency and Educational Malfunctioning," Intellect 104 (March 1976): 451.

²Vermont Royster, Wall Street Journal, cited by George Gallup, "Public Schools: Their Problems, Their Future," NASSP Bulletin (May 1975):5.

³Glen A. Lyons, "The Higher Illiteracy," Harper's, September 1976, p. 34.

⁴Ibid.

⁵Ibid.

5. Only half the seventeen-year-olds in the United States can read college freshman-level materials.¹
6. Researchers Lipset and Ladd surveyed 4,400 professors at 161 colleges and reported that virtually all faculty members said that many students with whom they come in close contact "are seriously underprepared in basic skills, such as those required for written and oral communication"²
7. On the Minnesota Scholastic Aptitude Test, which is given to 90 percent of high-school juniors in Minnesota, scores have declined steadily since the mid-1960s; Iowa Tests of Educational Development have shown similar results³

Dissatisfaction in business sector

In addition to outspoken members of the press and college faculties, the business sector has been equally vocal in expressing dissatisfaction with the lack of communication skills displayed by the current generation. Erickson has testified:

Those who employ graduates of high schools decry the inability of workers to prepare memorandum reports, letters, and formal reports that are understandable and free of glaring errors in syntax, rhetoric [sic], and mechanics. Among the most frequently mentioned weaknesses in writing ability are: inaccurate use of words, inability to spell correctly, poor punctuation skill, inability to apply correctly some of the most basic grammar rules, weak capitalization skill, lack of

¹Malcolm G. Scully, "Only Half of 17-Year-Olds Found Able to Read Well," Chronicle of Higher Education, 14 (28 March 1977):2.

²"Paychecks, Dropping Enrollments Causing Campus Professor Blues," Washington Post, reprinted in Tuscaloosa News, 9 January 1978, p. 8.

³Malcolm G. Scully, "What's Causing the Drop in College Entrance Scores?" Chronicle of Higher Education 11 (17 February 1976):3.

consistency in expressing numbers, and inability to compose simple messages.¹

In 1975 the Advisory Council for Technical-Vocational Education in Texas completed a statewide survey, "Qualities Employers Like, Dislike, in Job Applicants."² Employers were asked to respond concerning entry-level jobs requiring high school education. Two of ten leading reasons employers gave for rejecting applicants after the job interview were: (1) "inability of applicant to communicate during the interview" and (2) "poorly filled out job application form." When asked to cite areas of improvement needed in education to prepare for entry into full-time work, employers ranked in seventh place "the ability to write and speak effectively."

In 1976 the National Secretaries Association administered an examination to 746 business education students at high school and post-secondary levels throughout the United States for the purpose of selecting the recipient of the "Miss Future Secretary Award." The scoring of the examination implied that nationwide business students need more work on vocabulary, particularly in the area of word relationships, meaning of words, and word division.³

¹Erickson, "Using the Typewriter for Learning: Writing," p. 148.

²Kenneth W. Brown, "What Employers Look For in Job Applicants," Business Education Forum 30 (April 1976):7.

³Jerre E. Gratz, "Analysis of Examination for Future Secretaries," Journal of Business Education 51 (May 1976): 370.

In a survey of twenty-five executives chosen by random sample from "Fortune 500" corporations, Hammer found that the majority of those interviewed cited a need for improved basic skills and the development of accuracy.¹ Hammer stated that managers "expect careful proofreading."

Functional literacy

Beginning in 1972 nine major committees, councils, panels, task forces, and agencies were commissioned to conduct inquiries into the condition of the American public high school. Among those were the Carnegie Commission on Higher Education, the National Commission on the Reform of Secondary Education, and The Task Force on Secondary Schools in a Changing Society. At no other time in history have so many statements on needed improvements in secondary education been issued in a brief period of less than four years.² Bruce, Firth, Grimsley, and Halverson reviewed the proposals and recommendations of the nine committees and organized them into categories. Concerning program, the reviewers found the recommendation to "establish improvement of basic skills" as a top priority. The recommendation was expanded to suggest the provision of resources, incentives,

¹George Hammer, "The Outlook for Office Jobs: A Survey of the Fortune 500," Delta Pi Epsilon Journal, 18 (November 1975):1-5, as cited by Fred S. Cook and Frank W. Lanham, "R & D," Business Education World, (May-June 1976), p. 15.

²Roy E. Bruce, et al., "A Review of Recent Proposals for Reform in Secondary Education," Educational Forum 40 (March 1976):276.

and rewards for teachers who commit themselves to this task. Of the report from the National Commission on the Reform of Secondary Education, the review stated:

There is a clear urgency implied in these goal statements: The high school has the obligation to certify that every graduate has mastered the skills of reading and writing to a level of functional literacy . . . and the skills of computation to a level sufficient for the management of household responsibilities.¹

College writing skills

Concerning writing skills at the college level, U. S. Education Commissioner Ernest L. Boyer deplored in an Associated Press release:

I cannot believe sometimes the sloppy sentences that are found in correspondence or in college compositions. . . . Direct, clear, forceful expression is a reflection of clear and uncluttered thinking. I'm convinced that American education must once again focus on this essential goal.²

William D. Schaefer, executive secretary of the Modern Language Association, concurred with Boyer, "My impression is that on a national level we have failed--have continued to fail--to meet the challenge of illiteracy among college-level students."³

Dr. L. Edward Mullins, of The University of Alabama School of Communication, has pointed out:

Symptoms of poor writing are visible in all areas of study. . . . The problems won't have the improvement we

¹Ibid., p. 149.

²"Educator Assails Jargon," Tuscaloosa News, 2 December 1977, p. 12.

³"Crisis in English Writing," Chronicle of Higher Education 9 (September 23, 1974):1, 6.

want until there is more emphasis at the elementary, junior high, and high school levels on writing, spelling, and grammar. Right now, students are coming to college so handicapped in these areas they are having to back up and learn to write before they can go on with their studies.¹

Robert Farrell, dean of writing at Cornell University stated, "The writing decline is not only marked, but it's massive. This is not a national problem; it's an international one. My colleagues in Sweden and Germany are experiencing the same thing we are here."²

Scully reported that after the media stepped up its focus on the problem, a vast number of programs were instigated to help correct writing deficiencies among high school and college students. However, many English teachers agree with Astro of Oregon State University who contends that "the responsibility for teaching writing should lie with the entire faculty, not just professors of English."³

English across the curriculum

Although it is generally conceded that the "writing crisis" is no new development, current demands for accountability, relevance, and vocational competencies make the time right for attention to the problem and concentrated effort for remedial action. The current situation places

¹"Poor Writing Said National Problem," Tuscaloosa News, 31 October 1977, p. 5.

²"Colleges Trying Again to Teach Students How to Write," Tuscaloosa News, 28 September 1977, p. 41.

³"'Writing Crisis' Spurs Big Corrective Effort," Chronicle of Higher Education 13 (18 October 1976):12.

reemphasis on the adage: "Every teacher is a teacher of English." In recent years it has become apparent that there should be more research into the needs of English across the curriculum. Charles Stuart-Jervis has said, ". . . English teaching is a shared responsibility in a way that no other subject is, for it cuts across all boundaries."¹

The need for reinforcement of basic English rules among students suggested a need for this study involving the integration of special emphases in the typewriting course. If it can be determined that part of typewriting class periods can be devoted beneficially to the learning of communication skills, such evidence could be important to the development of programs and materials for improving these skills.

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of the study was twofold: (1) to develop materials to modify the traditional beginning typewriting course at the college level to include special emphasis on proofreading, capitalization, punctuation, spelling, and word division without deleting or deemphasizing any aspect of the traditional course content and (2) to determine the effect of this special emphasis on the achievement of both typewriting skills and proofreading skills in recognizing errors in capitalization, punctuation, spelling, and word division.

¹Charles Stuart-Jervis, "The Most Important Subject," Times Educational Supplement (20 September 1974), p. 59.